THE EFFECT OF SOCIAL CONDITIONS ON PSYCHOLOGICAL DISTRESS IN MINNEAPOLIS NEIGHBORHOODS

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Abstract

This study investigates how neighborhood is associated with psychological distress and the indirect effects of discrimination, perceived safety, and community cohesion. Data come from the 2014 Survey of the Health of All the Population and the Environment (SHAPE), which reports on the overall health of adults and children in the Twin Cities. Specifically, this study analyzes data from 3,323 respondents from four Minneapolis neighborhoods. The results from a binary logistic regression indicate that residents living in North, Northeast, and Central neighborhoods had significantly higher self-reports of psychological distress than residents living in Southwest neighborhood. Discrimination, perceived safety, and community cohesion have an indirect effect on psychological distress and account for the group differences between North and Northeast neighborhoods and Southwest neighborhood. When assessing education, age, and income, the results demonstrate that all neighborhoods remain significant. The findings indicate that policy aimed toward eliminating discrimination and promoting community cohesion could improve mental health outcomes in Minneapolis neighborhoods.

Introduction

- Neighborhoods are a universal facet of urbanized communities and they serve an important role in shaping one's overall well-being (Rios, Aiken, & Zautra, 2012)
- Neighborhood disparities and social contexts can worsen mental health outcomes
- Research on neighborhoods and mental health outcomes have examined the direct effects of social environmental factors, but few studies have explored:
  - Discrimination
  - Perceived safety
  - Community cohesion
- The proposed model combines these factors to understand whether they have an indirect effect on the relationship between four Minneapolis neighborhoods and psychological distress

Research Question: To what extent do social-environmental factors indirectly impact the relationship between neighborhood and psychological distress

H_1: Minneapolis neighborhoods will differ in levels of psychological distress

H_2: Discrimination, safety, and cohesion will have indirect effects on the relationship between neighborhoods and distress

Methods

- Data were collected from the 2014 Survey of Health of All the Population and the Environment (SHAPE)
- The respondents included 3,323 from North (N=768), Northeast (N=835), Central (N=747), Southwest Minneapolis (N=973)

Participants

- Age M=52.19 years, SD=16.38, range= 25-99
- 63.3% female
- Race: White (83.7), Non-White (16.3%)
- Participants with mild to severe mental illness: 16.3%

Measures

- Psychological Distress measured using Kessler-6 Scale with *α=.86*
- Community connectedness single-item (5-point Likert)
- Discrimination single-item (5-point Likert)
- Perceived neighborhood safety single-item (4-point Likert)

Results

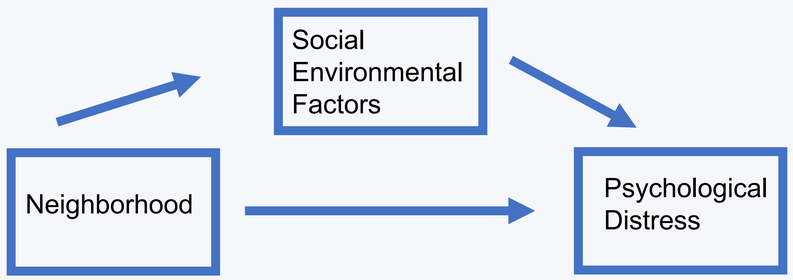


Table 1

	B	Sig.	Exp (B)
North	.124	.454	1.132
Northeast	.253	.098	1.288
Central	.462	.002*	1.587
Discrimination	.451	.000*	1.569
Community Cohesion	-.322	.000*	.725
Safety from Crime	-.291	.000*	.747
Constant	-.913	.002	.401

Table 2

	B	Sig.	Exp (B)
North	-.070	.692	.933
Northeast	.093	.555	1.098
Central	.212	.180	1.237
Discrimination	.388	.000*	1.473
Safety	-.229	.002*	.795
Cohesion	-.238	.000*	.788
Education	-.208	.015*	.812
Race	-.094	.519	.911
Age	-.026	.000*	.975
Income	-.698	.000*	.498
Constant	2.392	.000	10.936

Discussion & Implications

- This study demonstrates that the indirect effects of the social-environmental factors explain the relationship between neighborhoods and distress for residents in North and Northeast Minneapolis, but the factors did not explain differences for Central
- When assessing the indirect effects of social-environmental factors and demographic factors, the relationship between neighborhood and psychological distress was not significant for all neighborhoods
- This study revealed disparities in distress among Minneapolis neighborhoods. The findings contribute to the community and policy maker's understanding of mental health disparities in Minneapolis

Limitations

- A significant limitation of this study was the low response rate from minority populations
- The overall response rate of the SHAPE survey was 22%
- Race may not have been significant because all minorities were combined into one non-white variable in the analyses, thereby not accounting for important group differences
- Respondents 18-24 were excluded from the survey because of the low response rate
- The results have limited generalizability to other cities given that all cities and neighborhoods are unique

Future Research

- Based on these study findings, policy aimed toward increasing social cohesion and decreasing discrimination may decrease rates of psychological distress in Minneapolis neighborhoods
- Research should examine the indirect effects of social-environmental factors in St. Paul
- Contextual variables beyond social cohesion, discrimination, and crime should be explored
- Statistical analyses may need to be replicated using a multilevel mediation approach to account for individual and group differences using longitudinal data